

Corner routines

Corner routines are the most rehearsed set pieces in football. This guide explains the main attacking and defending principles, the difference between inswingers and outswingers, and the patterns teams use to create chances from corners.

Set piece routines [Read about corner kicks](#)

What corner routines are

A corner routine is a planned, rehearsed pattern of play used at a corner kick. Every team practises corners on the training ground. Each routine has a specific delivery type, a specific runner pattern, players assigned to block defenders, and a specific player picking up the second ball outside the box. The routine is designed to give the attacking team the best chance of meeting the cross with a clear header or shot.

Corners are one of the most studied set pieces because they occur regularly and can create clear chances. A team that is good at corners can turn a small number of routine attacking moments into a meaningful source of extra goals over a season.

The basic principles

Most attacking corner routines share the same underlying ideas.

Specific runs

Attackers do not arrive in the box at the same moment. They time their runs to meet the ball at different points — near post, far post, central, edge of the area — to give the kicker multiple options.

Blockers and screens

One or more attackers run in front of defenders to free a teammate. The defender has to choose between staying with their original man or staying behind the blocker, and either choice creates a problem.

The right delivery

The kicker chooses the delivery to suit the runs and the defending setup. Inswinging crosses threaten the goal directly, while outswinging crosses can suit late runners attacking the ball at speed.

Second-ball positions

A planned routine includes what happens if the cross is cleared. A teammate stands on the edge of the box ready to win the second ball, with attackers ready to recycle the move.

Inswinger versus outswinger

The choice of delivery shapes everything about the routine.

Inswinging corners

Curve towards the goal as they travel through the air. They can threaten the goal directly and create difficult decisions for the goalkeeper, especially if attackers crowd the most dangerous zones without committing fouls.

Outswinging corners

Curve away from the goal as they travel. They can suit late runners attacking the ball at speed and may reduce the goalkeeper's ability to claim the cross cleanly.

When to use inswingers

Many teams use inswingers when they want to threaten the six-yard area directly. The kicker is usually a player whose stronger foot delivers an inswinger from that side — a left-footer from the right corner, a right-footer from the left.

When to use outswingers

Teams who prefer late runs to early ones, or who want to keep the goalkeeper away from the cross, prefer outswingers. Some teams switch between the two based on the opposition's defensive setup.

Common attacking routines

Several rehearsed patterns are used widely.

The near-post flick is one of the oldest. An attacker runs to the near post, gets in front of the defender, and flicks the ball on with the back of the head or shoulder. A second attacker arrives at the far post or central area to finish the flick on. Many teams have used this routine for decades.

The packed box routine sends most of the team's attacking players into the area, with specific runners attacking specific zones — near post, far post, edge of the six-yard box, penalty spot. The number of bodies in the box is itself a tactic, designed to overload the defence and create space through movement.

The short corner offers a different option. Two players combine near the corner flag, pulling defenders out of the box and creating a different angle for the cross. A short corner is most useful against teams whose defending depends on their height in the box — taking them out of the area first changes the balance.

Defending corners

Defending corners is just as organised as attacking them.

[Read more on zonal marking](#)

Zonal marking

Defenders are placed in specific spots in the penalty area — the near post, the centre of the box, the back post, the edge of the six-yard area. Each defender attacks any cross that comes into their zone, regardless of who is there.

Man-to-man marking

Each defender is assigned a specific opposition attacker. They follow that attacker wherever they go in the box and try to win the duel when the cross arrives.

Mixed marking

Most teams now use a combination — zonal markers covering the most dangerous spots, with man-markers on the opposition's most threatening aerial attackers. The combination tends to work better than either pure system.

The near-post defender

A defender is often assigned to the near-post zone to attack low or near-post deliveries, stop flick-ons and protect the space immediately in front of goal.

Rest defence and the counter-attack threat

Corners are dangerous for the defending team, but they can also expose the attacking team.

Most defending teams keep one or two attackers high up the pitch at corners, ready to break forward if the ball is cleared. A counter-attack from a defended corner can be dangerous because the attacking team has committed numbers forward and may have fewer players behind the ball.

This is why the attacking team needs rest defence at corners. The second-ball player has to compete for loose clearances, while deeper players protect against the first forward pass. A team that loses too many second balls at corners ends up defending counter-attacks instead of sustaining pressure.

[Read about defensive transitions](#)

The rise of set piece coaches

Corners have become important enough for dedicated specialists.

Many top-level teams now employ a dedicated set piece coach whose only job is to design and rehearse routines for both attacking and defensive set pieces. Their work is detailed and statistical — analysing the opposition's defensive setup, designing routines specifically to exploit it, and refining the team's deliveries based on data and video.

This is a relatively new development. For most of football's history, set pieces were practised by the team as a whole or by the assistant coach. The arrival of dedicated specialists has driven up the quality of routines at the top of the game, and the gap between teams with strong set piece coaching and those without has become more visible.

